

Researchers have discovered that a baby's brain works faster and is potentially smarter than an adult's brain. How do we know this? Researchers at Oxford University in 2007 discovered that babies have 41 per cent more neurons than the average adult. A neuron in the brain is a specialised cell whose function is to transmit information throughout the body. The reason an adult brain has less neurons is due to something called synaptic pruning. Synapses are essentially connectors between neurons in your brain, and when we stop using these connections the brain trims them away so that it becomes more efficient. In this way, the brain develops stronger, more naturally occurring pathways, if you like, to support those activities we're doing regularly. For example, I learned to play the piano at age five. By age thirteen I'd reached an eighth grade level, which is the highest graded level, and due to the fact I was practising for at least an hour most days the brain would have strengthened the connections between those neurons relating to my ability to play. But today I rarely play, which means my brain has pruned away these connections and allocated energy towards other skills I use more regularly.

If we want to build stronger habits and become more skilled at something, we want to build these strong synaptic connections. If we want to become better at basketball, we need to practice regularly, and if we want to become better at our finances, we need to create patterns, habits and systems that strengthen these neural pathways.

An easy way for us to build new habits is to connect them with an existing habit. James Clear, in his book *Atomic Habits*, calls this practice 'habit-stacking'. By attaching a new habit to an existing habit, you're essentially using the strength of an existing synaptic connection to your advantage.

Clear's theory of habit-stacking can be an easy way for Discerners to automate their financial habits. Some examples of habit stacks might be:

After I brush my teeth at night, I will immediately put my work-out clothes at the end of the bed ready for the morning

When I turn off my car when I arrive home after work, I will sit and complete six sets of box breathing before I open the door